

Texas - 2026 Preseason Primer

2026 COLLEGE FOOTBALL PRESEASON PRIMER | SEC

Legend: trend - ● ↑ better · ● ↔ similar · ● ↓ worse · **assessment** - ● strong/positive · ● average/mixed/uncertain · ● weak/negative · ◆ new player or coach

1. 60-Second Briefing

Initial conclusions

Question	Answer
How good?	Top-10 caliber with a national-title ceiling, but the schedule and reconfigured protection/defensive spine leave less margin than the brand-name talent suggests.
Preseason consensus	AP No. 5 (1483 points) · SEC media 2nd (57 first-place votes) · SP+ No. 6
Returning production	71% (No. 3) overall · Off. 77% (No. 1) · Def. 64% (No. 19)
Primer power rating	+23.0 points vs. average FBS
Expected season	8.2 wins · likely 8-4
Net vs. 2025	● ↑ Similar-to-better overall, with a higher offensive ceiling and more defensive replacement risk.
Confidence	Medium-high

2026 identity: Steve Sarkisian builds around QB Arch Manning, WR Cam Coleman/WR Ryan Wingo and a renewed emphasis on a more dependable run game.

Bottom line: Texas can contend for the SEC/playoff, but No. 1 SOS, OL health and defensive turnover make 8-4 compatible with top-10 quality.

Beats expectations if: QB Arch Manning unlocks WR Cam Coleman/WR Ryan Wingo, OT Trevor Goosby/OL Laurence Seymore III stabilize the line, and EDGE Colin Simmons/LB Rasheem Biles prevent a major defensive drop.

Disappoints if: OL/RB instability hurts efficiency and the rebuilt linebacker/secondary groups are exposed by repeated top-20 opponents.

Five things to remember

- Returning production:** QB Arch Manning returns as the established starter, and Texas enters with 77% offensive returning production (No. 1).
- ★ **WR Cam Coleman:** WR Cam Coleman and WR Ryan Wingo give Sarkisian a high-end receiver pairing; WR Cam Coleman carries first-team national/SEC recognition.
- Offensive line:** The OL is talented but fluid: OT Trevor Goosby is managing a bone bruise, while OL Laurence Seymore III, OL Brandon Baker, OT Melvin Siani and IOL Cole Hutson shape the final five.
- 2025 baseline:** Six 2025 players were drafted and LB Ty'Anthony Smith was dismissed Aug. 21; the defense has less continuity than the overall roster number suggests.
- Schedule pressure:** SP+ SOS is No. 1, with Ohio State plus Tennessee, Oklahoma, Florida, Ole Miss, LSU and Texas A&M.

2. 2025 in Context

Traditional Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Record	10-3 (6-2 SEC)	● Excellent
Scoring	30.5 PPG	● Good / above average
Total offense	388.5 YPG	● Average / mixed
Rush offense	137.8 YPG · 4.2 YPC	● Below average
Pass efficiency	7.74 YPA · 28 TD / 7 INT	● Good / above average
Third downs	39.2%	● Average / mixed
Scoring defense	20.3 PPG allowed	● Very good
Total defense	338.8 YPG allowed	● Good / above average
Rush defense	103.9 YPG · 3.1 YPC	● Elite
Pass defense	234.9 YPG · 6.57 YPA · 18 TD allowed	● Good / above average

Texas won 10 games behind a stronger defense (No. 14 rush, No. 28 scoring); the offense was No. 70 total/No. 90 rushing, with better pass efficiency (No. 38).

Advanced Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Opp.-adjusted offense	+4.91 · No. 22	● Very good
Off. EPA/play	+0.104 · No. 27	● Very good
Off. success rate	41.3% · No. 92	● Below average
Off. explosive-play rate	11.8% · No. 72	● Average / mixed
Havoc allowed	15.7% · No. 82	● Average / mixed
Opp.-adjusted defense	+7.03 · No. 16	● Very good
Def. EPA/play allowed	-0.143 · No. 15	● Elite
Def. success rate allowed	38.7% · No. 37	● Good / above average
Def. explosive-play rate allowed	10.0% · No. 26	● Very good
Havoc created	17.3% · No. 31	● Very good

Advanced-stat read: Defense was the cleaner championship trait (No. 15 EPA allowed, No. 16 adjusted). Offense rated well overall but was only No. 92 in success rate, matching the inconsistent run/third-down profile.

EPA and success rate use CFB Graphs regular-season data. Explosive rate uses regular-season non-garbage-time cfbfastR plays; explosive = 10+ yd rush or 20+ yd pass. Havoc = TFL + forced fumbles + passes defended per play. Lower is better for defensive rates and offensive havoc allowed.

3. Coaching

Role	2026 status	Quick impact
HC / offensive play-caller	Steve Sarkisian - Returning HC; offensive play-calling to Sarkisian from reporting	● ↔ Steve Sarkisian keeps offensive authority and play-calling continuity at the top of the staff.
OC	Kyle Flood - Returning OC/OL	● ↔ Kyle Flood's return preserves OL/offensive coordination continuity around Sarkisian's play-calling.
DC	◆ Will Muschamp - New/formal 2026 defensive coordinator; exact primary game-day defensive caller unresolved	● ↔ Coordinator role is clear; primary game-day caller remains unresolved

4. Key Roster Movement

Offense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ WR Cam Coleman	Auburn	● ↑ Featured receiver with first-team national/SEC recognition.
◆ RB Hollywood Smothers	NC State	● ↔ Major backfield candidate; exact workload is open.
◆ OT Melvin Siani	Wake Forest	● ↑ Set at right tackle, filling a first-unit need.
IOL Cole Hutson	Return	● ↑ Fifth-year return adds experienced interior depth.

Out	To	Loss
RB Quintrevion Wisner	Florida State	● ↓ 2025 leading rusher leaves; Texas must redistribute the backfield workload.
RB CJ Baxter	Kentucky	● ↔ Another 2025 back departs; the new rotation has talent but less continuity.
OL DJ Campbell	NFL (Miami), Round 6, No. 200	● ↓ Starting OL departure compounds the 2026 line reconfiguration.
TE Jack Endries	NFL (Cincinnati), Round 7, No. 221	● ↓ All-13-game 2025 starter leaves, creating a meaningful TE replacement task.

Offensive net: ● ↑ Higher ceiling behind QB Arch Manning/receiver talent, with backfield and OL turnover limiting stability.

Defense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ LB Rasheem Biles	Pittsburgh	● ↑ First-team national/SEC recognition makes him a high-value replacement.
◆ LB Justin Cryer	Florida State	● ↔ Projected primary nickel linebacker after LB Ty'Anthony Smith's dismissal.

Out	To	Loss
LB Anthony Hill Jr.	NFL (Tennessee), Round 2, No. 60	● ↓ Second-round draft loss removes a major 2025 defensive contributor.
EDGE/LB Trey Moore	NFL (Miami), Round 4, No. 130	● ↓ Material edge loss alongside other front-seven turnover.
DB Malik Muhammad / Michael Taaffe	Muhammad: NFL (Chicago), Round 4, No. 124; Taaffe: NFL (Miami), Round 5, No. 158	● ↓ Two drafted secondary starters depart while the 2026 back-end alignment remains fluid.
LB Liona Lefau	Colorado	● ↓ A 21-start linebacker leaves, reducing experienced continuity.
LB Ty'Anthony Smith	Dismissed	● ↓ Experienced starting candidate was removed Aug. 21, forcing a late role redistribution.

Defensive net: ● ↔ Still strong, but NFL/transfer/dismissal losses create more volatility than 2025.

5. How They Play

Phase	Identity	What works	Main vulnerability
Offense	Sarkisian-led offense built around QB Arch Manning, with a stated 2026 emphasis on greater physicality and being able to run when opponents expect the run.	Quarterback continuity and high-end receiver talent.	Protection/OL health and whether a new RB distribution can fix the 2025 success-rate/rushing inconsistency.
Defense	Nickel-heavy structure with EDGE Colin Simmons as the premier edge threat and LB Rasheem Biles/LB Justin Cryer featured at linebacker under Muschamp.	Proven pass-rush/athletic ceiling and a 2025 defense that was elite-to-very-good by EPA, rush defense and explosive prevention.	Replacing LB Anthony Hill Jr., EDGE/LB Trey Moore, DB Malik Muhammad, DB Michael Taaffe and LB Liona Lefau, plus the late LB Ty'Anthony Smith dismissal, while secondary roles settle.
Special teams	Return-game strength with new primary specialists.	WR/RS Ryan Niblett has top preseason return recognition; K Gianni Spetic has a positive scrimmage showing.	Punter/kicker/long-snap transitions create more uncertainty than the return game.

6. Unit Grades

Unit	Grade	vs. 2025	Confidence	Why
QB	● A–	● ↑	High	Established starter in Sarkisian's offense; quarterback certainty is the biggest reason Texas can sustain top-10 expectations.
RB	● B+	● ↔	Medium	Transfer RB Hollywood Smothers leads a talented but redistributed backfield after the top two 2025 rushers left.
WR	● A–	● ↑	High	WR Cam Coleman and WR Ryan Wingo give QB Arch Manning a high-end outside pairing with major preseason recognition.
TE	● B	● ↓	Medium	TE Jack Endries leaves after starting all 13 games, so the room must replace proven first-unit production.
OL	● B+	● ↔	Medium-low	OT Trevor Goosby and veteran IOL Cole Hutson anchor a talented line whose health and final five remain fluid.
DL/Edge	● B+	● ↔	Medium-high	EDGE Colin Simmons supplies elite disruption, but Texas must replace multiple front-seven contributors.
LB	● B+	● ↓	Medium	LB Rasheem Biles is a high-end addition, but LB Anthony Hill Jr., LB Liona Lefau and LB Ty'Anthony Smith are major losses.
Secondary	● B	● ↓	Medium-low	S Kobe Black is a key returning piece, but drafted DB Malik Muhammad/DB Michael Taaffe leave an unsettled alignment.
Special teams	● B+	● ↔	Medium	WR/RS Ryan Niblett anchors the return game while new primary specialists add uncertainty.
Coaching	● A–	● ↔	High	Steve Sarkisian/Kyle Flood provide continuity; new DC Will Muschamp has one unresolved game-day calling detail.
Overall	● A–	● ↑	Medium-high	Top-10 caliber with a national-title ceiling, but the schedule and reconfigured protection/defensive spine leave less margin than the brand-name talent suggests.

7. Players to Know

Recognition status: official conference honors and major award watchlists through August 24, 2026.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
★ Arch Manning	QB	● National star / high-end returning starter	Walter Camp 1st team · SEC Coaches 2nd team · SEC Media 2nd team · Maxwell · Walter Camp POY	Established starter in Sarkisian's offense; quarterback certainty is the biggest reason Texas can sustain top-10 expectations.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
★ Cam Coleman	WR	● National star	AP 1st team · Walter Camp 2nd team · SEC Coaches 1st team · SEC Media 1st team · Biletnikoff · Maxwell · Walter Camp POY	A featured transfer receiver with elite preseason recognition who can change the passing-game ceiling.
★ Colin Simmons	EDGE	● National star / defensive centerpiece	AP 1st team · Walter Camp 1st team · SEC Coaches 1st team · SEC Media 1st team · Bednarik · Walter Camp POY	Texas needs his disruptive presence to stabilize a defense replacing multiple NFL-bound contributors.
★ Rasheem Biles	LB	● National star / impact transfer	AP 1st team · Walter Camp 1st team · SEC Coaches 1st team · SEC Media 1st team · Bednarik · Nagurski · Butkus · Walter Camp POY	Current nickel role plus elite recognition make him the key newcomer in the rebuilt linebacker level.
Ryan Wingo	WR	● High-end conference starter	SEC Coaches 3rd team · SEC Media 3rd team · Biletnikoff	Returning major receiver gives Manning continuity opposite Coleman.
Trevor Goosby	OT	● National-level tackle when available	AP 1st team · Walter Camp 1st team · SEC Coaches 1st team · SEC Media 1st team · Outland	Projected LT and one of the roster's most decorated players, but his bone bruise is a material protection/availability monitor.
Ryan Niblett	WR/R S	● Elite return specialist	SEC return/specialist recognition · Paul Hornung	Return-game value can create hidden-field-position edges while the primary specialists turn over.
Kobe Black	S	● High-upside secondary piece	-	same-school return with a confirmed move from corner to safety; his fit is central to the unsettled back-end alignment.

8. Schedule

Item	Assessment
Overall	● Brutal championship-caliber schedule; Texas has enough quality to survive it, but the path gives almost no free margin after nonconference warmups.
Difficulty	● 10/10 · SP+ SOS No. 1
Hardest stretch	at Tennessee → Oklahoma (neutral) → Florida → Ole Miss. Four consecutive games against SP+ top-20 opponents (No. 14, 11, 20, 16) after the first bye.
Swing games	at LSU, at Texas A&M, at Tennessee
Advantage	Five of the first six games are home or neutral, giving Texas some location relief before the schedule becomes heavily road-weighted in November.
Expected	8.2 wins · likely 8-4
Floor / ceiling	7-5 / 11-1

9. Betting Lens

Angle	Read
Market posture	Texas is likely to carry premium pricing because of QB Arch Manning, the No. 5 AP rank and title-level talent. Treat the schedule and OL/secondary uncertainty as reasons to demand matchup-specific edges rather than paying brand tax.
Back them when	Protection is intact and the opponent cannot force Texas into obvious passing downs; also attractive when EDGE Colin Simmons/LB Rasheem Biles can attack a shaky opposing protection or quarterback.
Fade/pass when	OT Trevor Goosby/OL Laurence Seymore III availability is compromised, the market prices Texas as an automatic elite rushing team, or the opponent has enough perimeter/quarterback quality to stress an unsettled secondary.
Key monitor	OT Trevor Goosby and OL Laurence Seymore III availability, final opening OL five, RB workload distribution, secondary/nickel alignment, exact defensive game-day caller, live market, injuries and weather
Week 1 baseline	Texas -27.0 vs. Texas State · early rating-based fair value; compare with the live market before betting. Live market: Texas -30.5 (CBS Sports, Aug. 25).

10. Summary

Texas has genuine national-title talent: QB Arch Manning is established, WR Cam Coleman/WR Ryan Wingo raise the passing ceiling, and EDGE Colin Simmons/LB Rasheem Biles give the defense elite anchors. The offense should be better if the reshuffled backfield and OL become more dependable than the 2025 run-game profile.

The restraint is schedule and replacement risk. SP+ SOS No. 1, fluid OL health, and concentrated losses at linebacker/secondary make **8.2 wins and 8-4** compatible with a top-10 team; Texas is most attractive when protection and defensive alignment are stable enough to justify the usual premium price.

About this primer

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Sources: [2026 roster](#) · [coaching staff](#) · [OL camp](#) · [LB dismissal](#) · [scrimmage](#) · [play-calling](#) · [NFL departures](#) · [OL return](#)

Last updated: August 25, 2026